

ARVIND RAO⁵⁰ MOULI RAMAN⁴⁰

TELECOM SOFTWARE PROVIDERS
FOUNDERS, ONMOBILE GLOBAL LIMITED
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 2000 \$18 million
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 260 crore

THE RIGHT CONNECTION

Every time you download a hello tune or a ringtone on your mobile phone, chances are you are helping a company called Onmobile earn some more revenue. It's hard to imagine that some people are making money, and a lot of it, by just providing ringtones and other voice-based products to cellphone users. But that is what has made Onmobile a Rs 260-crore turnover company, which is also the first Indian telecom value-added service provider to go public.

Arvind Rao and Chandramouli Janakiraman (better known as Mouli Raman) started Onmobile in 2000, during the last days of the dotcom age, because they were smart enough to realise that mobile services were the business of the future. With a venture capital of \$18 million, Rao as the CEO and Raman, the CTO, started a company based in California that would primarily provide speech-based voice portals for mobile service companies. In the next two years, however, they realised that the US was not a ripe market for what they were selling. Rao's worldwide experience of the telecom sector suggested that India and South-east Asia would be a better market for their products. The

entire team relocated to India, where Rao operated the sales and management, travelling all over the world to get clients while Raman handled the R&D and operations out of Bangalore, which is their head office. Their gamble paid off. The first client was Orange Mumbai, which now operates as Vodafone. "When the mobile companies found our products making a wave, they gave us the next circle, and we grew," says Raman. Today, Onmobile provides value-added services for every mobile carrier in the country—Vodafone, Airtel, BSNL, Idea, Reliance. Onmobile boasts offices in 18 countries. They recently acquired a company in France that has given them an additional presence in 10 countries and while their average employee age is 26, Rao would like to call himself the "grandfather in the office". Not that he behaves like one. He is appalled by the lack of waste management in India and wants to do something about it. Raman is the calmer one with a mission to start a yoga and mediation centre. They know that they have just begun to see the future, and though voice-based mobile products are mainly used for entertainment now, a host of opportunities are just waiting around the corner. *by Swagata Sen*

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